

Game developers in India

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Gaming is a great form of recreation and is now even becoming a profession for some. But has anybody wondered what makes these games great and who is responsible for that? The credit goes to the game developers. A game developer is basically a software developer who develops video games. There are many platforms for games — these days, you have PC games and console games. These are further sub-categorised. PC games include single-player games and online games, while console games have a wider range from Sony's Playstation series including the PSP, Microsoft's gaming console Xbox and Xbox 360 and even Nintendo's Wii and DS. First thing a developer needs is to narrow down on what he / she needs to specialise in.

A game cannot be made over night — it needs great thought, planning and execution before it can be made available to others. With this comes the need for an efficient workforce to back it all up. Typically, a game development team consists of programmers, game designers, artists and the management. India has an abundance when it comes to programmers in the IT sector. Designers, artists, sound engineers, producers and testers are the ones that are mostly outsourced by companies when needed. But before you even think about getting into this field, you need to have the passion and creativity for games and what really goes on behind the scene. When it comes to programming, you need to be proficient with C/C++, have knowledge in 2D vector math, 3D math, knowledge of Direct X and Open GL. And yes, before all this, you need to have a BE / BTech degree. You can't expect to approach a game developer by saying you have an idea for a game. If you want to be a game designer who works on levels and artwork, you need to know Adobe Photoshop, CorelDraw, 3ds Max, Maya and other such 3D animation software. Again remember, creativity must come from within. If you do not want to join the corporate world and want to stay independent, you really need to prove yourself and must have extensive knowledge in the above mentioned. In fact, to even approach a game

When it comes to India, there is definitely a shortage, as most opt for an MBA or are not even aware of game developments as a career option

developer, you need to have the proper paper work including a game design document (GDD) which could be anywhere between 2 to 200 pages a level. Just imagine the sizes of GDDs for MMORPGs, the amount of work going into each dungeon and level.

The game development industry is estimated to reach \$65 billion by 2011 in the US. In India itself, NASSCOM says, it's expected to value at \$212 million. But the question here is, when will India reach that level and are the companies here moving at the same pace as those in the US? Companies need to provide, not only to the Indian market, but possibly even a much wider user base, when it comes to game development. There are several companies in India that have begun to tap this Gold Mine. Outsourcing or off shoring has become an integral aspect in the production of most international game titles. Game development studios across the world are looking to out-source visual art elements such as game characters, vehicles, racing tracks, sports arenas and various game environments for games that are being developed. Many Game companies in India cater to this need and are contributing to some amazing upcoming games. All of this may sound great though it doesn't come easy. Aspiring Game studios need to match high quality expectations to be able to deliver on such international projects. Did you



know that Indian game companies have contributed to games like Microsoft's *Forza motor-sport*, EA's *Battlefield Modern Combat*, Atari's *Asterix and Obelix XXL2*, *Project Gotham Racing 4*, *Colin McRae Dirt*, *Guitar Hero* and many more. So where does India stand with all of this?

Some companies prefer to stick to a more traditional approach of gaming, where in people play games for leisure. Such games are called casual games and one such company present in India is Zapak. If you visit their website (www.zapak.com) you will find a huge list of games to choose from and these are mostly all browser-based games with a multiplayer aspect to them. Zapak has also won awards for their games including the UN Award for Excellence in Creativity for their game *Laadli* and when asked about how long it took to create the game, they claim, "It took more than 45 days to create *Laadli* and it cost us about Rs. 1.5 Lakhs." Talking about creating their games, "We have in-house developers and we also outsource our projects." Zapak has games which is meant for the Indian audience but Mr Saagar says that they have recently even started Zapak World which is meant for the world audience also. That's a really good step in India to create such a base. The platforms Zapak uses to create their games are Flash, Macromedia and Unity.

Recently FX Labs released the game *Ghajini*, which is based on the movie with the same title, with elements of the movie present in the game itself. We spoke with Mr. Sashi Reddi, Founder & CEO — FXLabs Studios, and asked him about the status of Game Development in India and he said, "We, at FXLabs, believe that the gaming market in India while still in its infancy is ripe for growth. As a company, we are betting that the market for top notch games based on recognizable Bollywood properties is the clear path to success. We are confident that consumers will perceive a high level of value in the products that we make, and it should serve to cement FXLabs in their minds as the premiere developer of games for the Indian market. FXLabs is making a significant investment in this particular market opportunity." Talking about *Ghajini*, we asked him how long it took them to make the game and also about the workforce that was used, he replied, "We take about 9-12 months to produce a game like *Ghajini* from Concept, Design to Implementation. The *Ghajini* game was completely built out of our own studios in Hyderabad. The main production team for *Ghajini* game consisted of about 30 people which included programmers, artists and testers." On asking him about the game *Ghajini* and the technology involved he said,

Upcoming titles from the Indian Developers: Dhruva Interactive: Conga Bugs, a casual PC game. FXLabs Studios: Inferno - A game based on Dante's Inferno. RZ2 Games: A secret MMOFPS is in development.

"We have adopted the latest DirectX technologies for Graphics in our games. For *Ghajini* we wrote a lot of good Shaders, but we had to pull them out of the game to maintain compliance with lower configuration graphics cards that are prevalent in India. Our survey of Indian hardware market made us aware that the masses don't have advanced 3D graphics cards and if we were to reach the mass audience we had to lower our specification for Graphics card requirement to most widely available Intel Integrated Graphics Chipset (G965). We had to optimize our Engine to run on low end graphics cards, while not compromising on game play. DirectX 10 and advanced graphics is available to the Indian audience today with the current generation AAA games, but the masses who don't have a 3D accelerated graphics card would have to wait for about a year to be able to play the current generation games."

We also spoke with Mr. Anthony Whitaker, the Technical Director of RZ2 Games, and asked him how long and also about the costs involved in creating a big budget game and he said, "It takes anywhere between two to five years to create a big budget title and can cost anything upto even \$13 million." When asked about what games have been created specifically for the Indian audience, he said, "We have mobile games like *Jalsa* and *Ashta Chamma* which are games based on the movies with the same name." We also asked if RZ2 Games was doing anything in relation to DX10 and Anthony replied, "We are not looking at DX10 games for India as that requires Windows Vista and a more powerful machine. Also, it does not have a large enough spread or even market share. We use technologies upto DX 9 and also create flash games. We create games for PC, PS2, Nintendo DS and even the iPhone." We also asked about other Indian companies approaching them for projects to which he replied, "Other companies like Zapak and FX Labs has approached us. Most of our development is in-house only though." He also spoke about RZ2 Games creating an MMOFPS, but couldn't reveal any information on that topic.

Dhruva Interactive is one of India's oldest Game Developers. When we Mr. K Rakesh Rao, CEO, about how long and how much the Game Development industry has improved, he replied, "Yes 12 years is a long time indeed! While the it was really slow for the first 5 to 6 years, things started picking up around 2003, with the emerging mobile games market, and the developer community has grown at a fast clip in the last couple of years. The consumer market is finally growing, thanks to the high decibel marketing and promotion by portals, console owners such as Microsoft and Sony,